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Theorising Incels and Co.: A Multidisciplinary Literature Review of the Manosphere

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ABSTRACT

This article will scope out the field of manosphere studies, providing a literature review of relevant and timely research into the manosphere, with a particular focus on Incels. The paper employs a multidisciplinary approach, arguing that there are three key disciplines in which research into the manosphere is occurring. These disciplines are masculinity studies (understood, as explained below, as an offshoot of feminist studies), clinical psychology, and linguistics. However, this article proves that there is very little conversation between the research in different disciplines. The article will be structured around these three fields, though comparative analysis will be applied to indicate the overlaps and distinctions of the subject-specific literature.

1 | Introduction

The manosphere is the umbrella term for communities of men online unified by their anti-feminist and anti-women rhetoric. Included within this term are disparate, often warring, factions, primary among which are Incels (a portmanteau of *involuntary celibate*), a group unified by their misogynist belief that they are maligned by women's right to refuse sex. Though the term Incel (or Invcel) was originally conceived by a woman in the 1990s seeking a likeminded community on early Internet forums, it has since become a community uniformly hostile towards women. Incels are joined in the manosphere by: Pick Up Artists (PUAs), who believe that men can learn to trick women into having sex with them; Men Going Their Own Way (MGTOWs), who seek to entirely remove themselves from women's company in both their personal and professional lives; Men's Right's Activists (MRAs), who campaign to raise awareness about women's wrongs; and online trolls, who target and abuse women in digital spaces. These groups hold violent and discriminatory beliefs, which have filtered into more mainstream social media and the offline world in the forms of acts of mass violence and increasing hostility towards women and girls in schools and workplaces, as well as dating and family life. The manosphere can be understood as the specifically misogynistic arm of the Alt-Right, although this conflation has been contested. Cultural and critical attention on the topic of the manosphere has intensified in the past eight years, owing in part to the increasing presence of the manosphere in mainstream digital spaces, as well as to high-profile terrorist attacks, such as the Isla Vista killings in 2014 and the Toronto killings in 2018. Both attacks were by Incels, and this contributes to the fact that Incels are the most well-known faction of the manosphere. As such, much of the research in this field is focussed specifically on Incels, though some of the research more ambitiously surveys the manosphere as a whole.

This article will scope out the field of manosphere studies, providing a literature review of relevant and timely research into the manosphere, with a particular focus on Incels, reflecting the current research landscape. This paper argues that there are three key academic disciplines in which research into the manosphere is occurring, though there is very little conversation between the research in different disciplines. These disciplines are masculinity studies, clinical psychology, and linguistics. The novelty of this paper lies in its multidisciplinary approach, and these disciplines have been selected owing to their prominence

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in manosphere studies. The article will be structured around these three fields, though comparative analysis will be applied to indicate the overlaps and distinctions of the subject-specific literature. The research contained within this literature review is primarily focussed on academic publications, though alternative-academic sources are a vital site of manosphere research, as will be further discussed below. The goal of this article is to provide a timely and comprehensive theoretical framework for existing literature on the manosphere and gesture towards future avenues for research into the manosphere; moreover, it aims to begin bridging the gap between the disciplines to encourage further interdisciplinary research in this field.

2 | Masculinity Studies

Masculinity studies as an academic field emerged in the mid-1980s, largely as a response to the women's liberation movement and the gay rights movement (Kimmel 1986, 517). Like women's studies, men's studies draws on social changes, as well as on academic development across multiple fields, including sociology, psychology, history, and linguistics[1]; 'influenced and often inspired by the women's movement's explicit challenge to traditional definitions of gender-appropriate behaviour, men have been wrestling with the meaning of masculinity' (Kimmel 1986, 518). Ging notes that the men's liberation movement—a key concern within the emerging discipline—was inspired by second-wave feminism in the 1970s, and it was committed to critiquing conventional understandings of masculinity, but it soon split into 'pro- and antifeminist factions [...] due largely to disagreements over the claim that male privilege adversely affects women' (Ging 2017, 2). Men's studies, like women's studies, has largely been subsumed into the broader subject of gender studies, but it remains vital as a standalone discipline. However, when working in masculinity studies, it is crucial to be aware of the antifeminist and misogynistic co-opting of men's liberation, in the manner of Men's Rights Activists. Despite MRAs' muddying of the field, phenomena such as the male suicide crisis, ongoing male violence (against people of all genders), and digital misogyny are some reasons for the ongoing need for masculinity studies. This is indicated by the ongoing relevance of formative theories of masculinity, such as Connell's theory of hegemonic masculinity (Connell 1995; 2005) and Kosofsky Sedgwick's theory of homosociality (Sedgwick 1985). It is within the purview of masculinity studies that some of the key research regarding the manosphere is happening. This is understandable, given the specifically gendered nature of the manosphere's worldviews.

A key text within the literature is 'Alphas, Betas, and Incels: Theorising the Masculinities of the Manosphere' (Ging 2017). This study provides a broad and systematic analysis of the manosphere's categories and relationships between them. This marked a development upon earlier studies that were more specific in their analyses, looking at digital communities where divergent masculinities propagated, such as in the male My Little Pony fandom (Nagle 2016), MMORPG videogames (Gelunas 2022), otherwise focussing on individual platforms such as Reddit and 4/chan (Nagle 2016). Ging's study '[determines] how antifeminist men are positioning themselves through the manosphere's discursive practices' and does so via a methodology of repeated searching and cross-comparison, using antifeminism as the baseline criterion (Ging 2017, 6–7). She confirms that technological affordances of social media have radically increased the flow of antifeminist ideas and information across groups, platforms, and geographies, and that hyperlinking and reposting have enabled the spread and homogenisation of manosphere rhetoric (Ging 2017, 7–8). She also found that the predominant route for digital antifeminist activism is not collective action, but rather targeted attacks on individual feminists; this is confirmed by popular, prominent feminists such as Caroline Criado Perez, Laura Bates, and Zoe Quinn, who have publicly experienced techniques such as doxing and dogpiling. Such techniques began as geek and gamer strategies—indicated by Quinn's experiences, as the epicentral victim of gamergate[2]—though they have since been extrapolated by the rest of the manosphere. The findings pertaining to organised personal attacks indicate a shift from a predominantly political to a broadly cultural discourse, and a shift in priorities from political action to personal affect.

Ging's research also outlined the shift from sex role theory (Messner 1998) relied upon by pre-Internet MRAs to the focus on evolutionary psychology, especially genetic determinism, to explain male/female behaviours and interactions. The manosphere's engagement with this field is limited to superficial interpretation in support of their claims that women are hypergamous and need to be dominated. These evolutionary biological concepts have been 'heavily masculinised and geekified' to give rise to a uniquely misogynist, heterosexist, and racist lexicon (Ging 2017, 12). Though Ging is one of the earliest theorists to comment on the language of the manosphere, it will be discussed in more depth below. Finally, Ging explores the contradictory discourses around homosexuality in the manosphere, where homophobic language is rife, but gay men are seen as allies of anti-women praxis: gay men are the original MGTOW. Though Ging does not refer to this, it is worth noting that lesbian and bisexual women are not afforded the same ostensible respect, as these identities are viewed as lies formed by feminism and hypergamy, manufactured to keep Incels celibate. As Ging concludes, while the manosphere is not an ideologically homogenous bloc, the 'ostensibly masculine formulations [...] can coalesce around any number of contentious issues [...] when the common goal is to defeat feminism or keep women out' (Ging 2017, 16). Manosphere networks are connected by sentiment, wherein personal suffering is mobilised and reified to build affective consensus about men's subjugation and women's domination: 'masculinity politics have reached a deeply affective and toxic juncture, representing significant threat to the capacity of digital feminisms and women [online]' (Ging 2017, 16). Ultimately, Ging's article is seminal for its holistic approach to manosphere masculinities, wherein it presents and problematises the distinct masculinities of the manosphere, related to both traditional and digital theories of masculinity, to present a detailed investigation of digital antifeminism.

Lisa Sigiura's chapter '"Women Get Away with the Consequences of Their Actions with a Pussy Pass": Incel's Justifications for Misogyny' in the *Palgrave Handbook of Gendered*

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Violence and Technology (2021) further develops on Ging's foundational research. This chapter explores the justifications presented by Incels that attempt to absolve their flagrant misogyny and, further to this, encourages further debate about the role of gender in extremist behaviours (Sugiura 2021a, 2021b, 8052). Sugiura specifies that, although Incels are an extreme manifestation of misogyny, their attitudes are 'symbolic of structural misogyny and patriarchal systems of socialisation' (Sugiura 2021a, 2021b, 8059–61). This type of extremism is not confined to online spaces, though it is facilitated and exacerbated by digital technologies embedded in our daily lives. Sugiura labels this 'New Tools for Old Beliefs' (Sugiura 2021a, 2021b, 8134). Analysing her data, she breaks down Incel justifications for misogyny into the following sections: misandry, rejection, and women as naturally inferior/corrupt. Due to not meeting hegemonic masculine standards, Incels view themselves as oppressed victims of evolutionary biology and misandry; though most people experience anxiety and rejection during their transition to adulthood, Incels find this all-consuming and overwhelming; and women are stripped of their human attributes and demonised as the evil other, which permits Incel aggression and hatred towards them. This chapter is vital in illuminating the influence and philosophy of Incels and how they justify their misogynistic world view. Sugiura's netnographic research into the manosphere—including her central thesis that the manosphere is a consequence of offline misogynistic culture that is enabled and exacerbated by digital technologies—will be analysed in further detail below, in the consideration of Sugiura's monograph *The Incel Rebellion*.

In *Political Masculinities,* Kaiser (2022) investigates Incels alongside religious fundamentalists and right-wing authoritarians to consider how they mobilise independently and connectively for the maintenance of patriarchy. Kaiser's work is novel in its global approach and its consideration of these three intersecting factions of contemporary oppressive extremists. For Kaiser, these groups are unified by their performative enactment of masculinity—a masculinity informed and normalised by Donald Trump—and their mobilisation by Internet technologies. These groups are motivated by their frustration about the increased number of women in power, in politics, business, media, and societal and familial structures. They have emerged in direct response to women and queer people's gains in rights, visibility, and professional success. Their particular form of masculinity and its prevalence is reflected in the rise of right-wing populist parties, spearheaded by figures such as Donald Trump and Jair Bolsonaro. Evangelicals, right-wing extremists, and masculinists—'angry white men' (Kaiser 2022)—have grown into a globally active authoritarian movement that is proving to be lasting and infectious, as indicated by the global increase in far-right ideologies and terrorist acts. For Kaiser, '[there] is a decidedly political current in which sexism has been radicalised and has taken on a political dimension' (Kaiser 2022), and her text constitutes an effort to explain why sexism has become such an important element of the authoritarian backlash and the gender-motivated origins of this new authoritarian right. Kaiser's global focus and consideration of Incels within a broader network of evangelicals and right-wing extremists contextualises the manosphere within the widest possible geo-political milieu. While the connection between the Alt-Right and the manosphere has been discussed in depth, Kaiser's work is original in its inclusion of Evangelicals as a further Red Pill organisation. Overall, masculinity studies is one of the key fields in which manosphere research is occurring, which is understandable given the overt focus on gender relations and male identities in the manosphere. Further research in this field could analyse the manosphere using traditional sociological theories, such as alienation or anormie theories, to place the manosphere within its wider, offline context.

3 | Clinical Psychology

While the literature within masculinity studies used theories of masculinity (both digital and otherwise) to investigate the relationship between manosphere philosophies and male identities, psychologists instead focus on the pathology, treatment, and ideologies of their Incel service users. Psychology as a discipline and praxis has often faced the question of how practitioners should deal with patients who espouse discriminatory world views, such as racism, xenophobia, homophobia, or sexism (Flores et al. 2020). When treating Incels, other members of the manosphere, or members of the Alt-right,[3] these issues are significant. Some of the tensions at play when psychologists address Inceldom, in both theory and practice, include whose wellbeing to prioritise, the practitioner's own wellbeing, and the moral and ethical obligations of counsellors and psychotherapists (BACP 2022).

The core text for psychological approaches to Incels is *Understanding and Treating Incels* (Van Brunt and Taylor 2021). The researchers outline the problem of Incels in specifically psychological terms:

> [The] incel's attitude toward women reinforces negative stereotypes, harms development, and increases negative interactions. This leads to further isolation and alienation of the incel from the larger society and they often find their only solace in the dark chat rooms of the internet. This loneliness can lead to an increase in depression and risk of suicide.
>
> (Van Brunt and Taylor 2021, 3)

Here, the focus is on the psychological state of individuals, as they are indoctrinated into Inceldom. Unlike in the other fields herein studied, the focus is on the individual rather than the broader on- or off-line society. They pay particular attention to the alienation and depression that afflicts Incels, noting that, for many men, being teased, bullied, or rebuffed has led to this ideology (although they acknowledge that there is a 'chicken and the egg' element, as Inceldom also alienates and depresses individuals). Incel ideology is born from 'a place of sadness, pain, frustration, and loneliness', and both the redpill and blackpill 'leave the incel with a growing sense of frustration, potential hopelessness, feelings of suicide, despair and a growing frustration [leading] to anger' and alienation (Van Brunt and Taylor 2021, 4–5). These negative emotions constitute a fertile breeding ground for reductive attitudes towards women and escalation to violence.

Van Brunt and Taylor's monograph primarily focuses upon their Incel Indoctrination Rubric (IIR) and its applications. Based on

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50 Incel-related attacks, Van Brunt and Taylor created a set of 20 core elements related to Incel thinking, feeling, behaviours, and environment; these factors were then operationalised into a scoreable rubric—the IIR (Van Brunt and Taylor 2021, ix). In their monograph, they score prominent cases using the IIR to illustrate how it can be used. They also developed three Incel case studies—set in school, college, and a workplace—to provide examples of how to use the IIR to better assess the depth of Incel beliefs and the risk of violence. Van Brunt and Taylor provide treatment and intervention options in both clinical and non-clinical settings for those seeking to help individuals deprogram from Incel indoctrination, which would also help reduce the risk of harms towards the individuals, women, and wider society. The 20 items within the IIR are divided into four categories that influence Incel thought: *Thinking, Feeling, Behaviour,* and *Environment*. *Thinking* qualities are related to cognitions the individual has that increase the buy-in to the incel worldview, enforced by online communities; *Feeling* qualities are the sentiments and corresponding reactions to their thoughts or experiences from others, and they often drive behaviours; *Behaviours* are outward manifestations of the cognitions, feelings, and emotions, and they relate to the risk factors; *Environmental* factors represent historical and cumulative experiences that further escalate the individual towards isolation, hardened thoughts, and potential violence (Van Brunt and Taylor 2021, 47–50). The rubric—intended to assist counsellors, psychologists, law enforcement, human resources, and BIT/CARE teams assess the degree of Inceldom in any given case—is the first step in a 3-stage assessment process (Van Brunt and Taylor 2021, 47). The IIR step is followed by determining the presence of risk factors and stabilisation influences, and then conducting a threat assessment process (Van Brunt and Taylor 2021, 47). In terms of treatment approaches, the researchers outline some of the treatment concepts that are most effective in addressing Incel thoughts, emotions, and behaviours (Van Brunt and Taylor 2021, 125–139). These are person-centred therapy, cognitive-behavioural therapy, the narrative approach to therapy, the metaphor technique, existential therapy, and transhistorical change theory. This monograph provides both a psychological approach to theorising Incels and a framework for locating, assessing, and treating Incel thinking, which in turn could mitigate some of the risks that Incels pose to themselves, individual victims, and society.

Broyd et al. (2023) have also researched Incels, violence, and mental disorder. Their article is a narrative review of Inceldom; like Van Brunt and Taylor, they also provide recommendations for best practice in risk assessment and clinical intervention. They note that mental illness is a major concern among the Incel community, with one sub-group calling themselves 'mentalcels'—a type of Incel who attributes their Inceldom to mental illness or neurodivergence (Broyd et al. 2023). External attention also focuses on this ostensible link—for example, much attention was paid to Elliot Rodger's autism and psychiatric medication in coverage of the Isla Vista massacre. Broyd et al. surveyed the current literature and found that the connections between mental illness and Inceldom can be categorised into the following groups: depression, hopelessness, and suicidality; psychosis; eating disorders and body dysmorphia (ED/BD); autism (although autism is not a mental illness); and personality disorders. Yet, it is noteworthy that they found no available data or research on the connection between ED/BD and Inceldom or personality disorders and Inceldom. The authors argue that this is due to a dearth of research rather than a lack of connection. They draw upon the existing literature of ED/BD online culture (such as proana content) and gender-based violence perpetrated by people with personality disorders to indicate the correlation. They organise clinical management into literature on risk assessment and clinical interventions (for which they primarily draw upon Van Brunt & Taylor's *Understanding and Treating Incels* [2021]). They utilise Hoffman's 'negative triad' (Hoffman et al. 2020)—that Incels have a negative view of themselves, the world, and their future—to explain the high prevalence of hopelessness in Incel thought processes. This combines with the 'triad of risk'—(a) fixation on a lack of sexual experience, (b) cognitive distortions, and (c) blaming women for their frustrations—which demonstrates the connection between Incel's mental ill health and the risks they pose, since they may escalate to violence if they feel misunderstood by society, and view harming themselves and/or others as their only option. Autism also increases vulnerability to risk factors that make individuals more likely to become Incels and potentially enact violence. These risk factors include difficulties navigating social interactions and increased likelihood of depression and anxiety. For clinical risk assessment, the researchers recommend following their checklist of indicators of Inceldom, which include internet use, relationship history, and misogynist attitudes. For clinical interventions, the researchers stress the need for a comprehensive formulation of the individual's problems, since Incels are complex and a non-homogenous group. They recommend cognitive behavioural therapy and compassion-focused therapy as potentially useful treatments.

Broyd et al. conclude that future research in this field should aim to work directly with Incels, though there are challenges associated with this, including risk to the practitioner and the us-and-them indoctrination that leaves Incels suspicious of non-Incels. This is the primary issue in psychological approaches to the manosphere: they lack any application of these theories to real-world clients. Decentring a clinical approach, ethnographic research would also give psychologists a more applied understanding of different facets of the manosphere. This is the approach undertaken by social psychologist O'Neill in her ethnographic study of London's 'seduction community' (O'Neill 2015), which found that, in-line with Sugiura's conclusions on Incels, sexism within this community does not deviate from culturally normalised sexism, but rather accelerates them. Though manosphere research in clinical psychology is valuable for its psychological profiling of Incels, it could be expanded to include other manosphere communities, further work in this field should be bisected into non-clinical research, such as social psychology, and the application of clinical research and its subsequent findings.

4 | Linguistics

This article now turns to its third field—linguistics—with a specific focus on the methodology of discourse analysis due to its prevalence in manosphere research. In one sense, discourse

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analysis is simply one way to study communicative language and its effects, though it does also have a further-reaching definition. In a Foucauldian sense, discourses can also relate to ideologies and power. Johnson states that 'anyone who wants to understand human beings has to understand discourse,' (Johnstone 2018, 6)—hence, anyone who wants to understand Incels, must endeavour to understand their discourse. This is arguably the most significant section of the literature review, since most studies on the manosphere are focussed on understanding and analysing its language, ideologies, systems, and methods.

Formative to the analysis of the manosphere's discourse is Jane's '"Your a Ugly, Whorish, Slut": Understanding E-Bile' [sic] (2014). It was the first study of its kind, providing an in-depth investigation of digital violence against women, with a specific focus on the language utilised by misogynists online. This article calls online vitriol targeted towards women 'e-bile' and examines the disconnect between representations of e-bile in media texts and academic literature. She found that many theorists have routinely trivialised the experiences of 'flaming'[4] targets, and academic discourses had heretofore largely overlooked it. Many studies that investigate manosphere language draw upon Jane's early intervention in online misogynistic language.

Linguistic studies into the manosphere have been both qualitative and mixed-method. Vink et al.'s qualitative study '"Because They Are Women in a Man's World": A Critical Discourse Analysis of Incel Violent Extremists and the Stories They Tell' (2023) analyses the misogynistic narratives shared by three prominent Incels: Elliot Rodger, Alek Minassian, and Scott Beierle. They found that Incel men expect women to provide feminine-coded (emotional, social, and sexual) services, while men are entitled to masculine-coded privileges (Vink et al. 2023). These privileges related to authority, power, and status. Vink et al. note the limitation of the persevering belief that Incel ideology is a matter of individual views—accounted for by mental illness, social isolation, and sexual frustration—instead of a part of the wider continuum of misogynistic beliefs in Western societies (Vink et al. 2023, 5–6). Their study examines Incel extremist (IE) speech in relation to social misogyny; they used critical discourse analysis to study IEs' spoken and written language via a sociocultural lens (Vink et al. 2023, 8). Using rhetoric from the three prominent IEs, the study detected IEs' sexist discourse patterns and pointed to how societal sexism can explain their narratives in North America. They conclude that 'sexism in North America maintains a patriarchal structure in which women provide feminine-coded services and men receive masculine-coded benefits' and that 'women are expected to supply males with emotional, social, and reproductive services under this dominating discourse. Incels want "attention," "affection," "sex," and "sympathy" [...] "admiration," "[nurturing]," and "comfort."' (Vink et al. 2023, 11–12). This study exemplifies how linguistic analysis can be utilised to understand Incel beliefs and contextualise them within broader society.

While Vink et al.'s study is qualitative, Jaki et al.'s mixed-method linguistic analysis of the now-defunct Incels.me forum (2019)[5]—studies the virtual community on the forum, in which linguistic analysis is used with a view to shedding light on the discourse of hatred in such forums, as well as surveying the in-group dynamics and how they construct major out-groups, primarily women. They investigated the misogynistic rhetoric in the forum, the demographics of the users, and the reasons for their behaviour. As well as outlining the members and beliefs on Incel forums, also aimed to illuminate the potential danger of such forums, asking how likely it is that the discourse in unmoderated forums for Incels leads to violent extremism (Jaki et al. 2019, 5). Wikipedia pages were used as a neutral point of comparison, since they are primarily written by the same demographic (men of variable ages, education, and ethnicity). They found that homophobia, racism, misogyny, and anti-feminism were key themes within the Incels.me forum. They also used automated text profiling to shed light on the sentiments, demographics, and psychological profiles of forum users. They found that 'due to the heterogeneity of the community [...] there is no standard in-group definition of inceldom', though the exclusion of '*normies* and *volcels*' were key indicators of the in-group, otherwise called truecels, 'that is, a legitimate and badly-off user' deserving of emotional support (Jaki et al. 2019, 14–17). They found that there is considerable disagreement within the community on which defining factors are the most prevalent, though they propose that potential criteria include a lack of stable personality and success in one's life (Jaki et al. 2019, 20). They also analysed the language to explore the relationship between Inceldom and violent extremism, and they organised their findings into group dynamics, incitement to violence, and threatening. They propose that automatic detection could be utilised to mitigate offline harm; machine learning—a field within AI—can be trained to detect violence with a statistical accuracy of 95.1% (Jaki et al. 2019, 25). Ultimately, they concluded that the key to identifying features of an online subculture is examining their language use, both quantitatively and qualitatively. They demonstrated that the forum is interspersed with subculture language and adolescent slang. In addition, there was a particular focus on words relating to physical appearance, sexuality, and gender, as well as a considerable amount of hate speech. Moreover, relating to the question of violence, they found that the forum is replete with incitement and explicitly violent fantasies, though part of these may be 'verbal tactics of self-enhancement in an online echo chamber' (Jaki et al. 2019, 26). This article provides a foundation of mixed-method linguistic analysis of Incel forums, and indicates how these can be used to (1) increase understanding, and (2) gesture towards pathways to change.

Pathways to change is the key concern of the 2018 policy brief by Zimmerman et al., in which they sketch out Incel discourses and the link between them and other forms of violent extremism, before going on to consider the policy implications of Inceldom. The labelling of Inceldom as terrorism is contentious, as media and government officials are reticent to classify Incel-related violence as terrorist acts, despite the nature of Incel violence meeting the expert and governmental requirements and definitions (Zimmerman et al. 2018, 2). The existing attacks have been premeditated, politically motivated, and they have perpetrated violence against civilians, which clearly designate Incel attacks as a form of terrorism (Zimmerman et al. 2018, 2). This therefore require Incel ideology to be explored as a form of violent extremism. In terms of policy implications, Zimmerman et al. locate as the most effective policies ones that address the ideology and act on early warning

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signs, ultimately concluding that holistic addresses to these ideologies and the environments in which they thrive is the most effective approach to preventing both large and small scale IE violence.

Zimmerman's article on the ideology of incels (2022) particularly investigates their use misogyny and victimhood as justification for political violence. She utilises a methodology of critical narrative analysis to assess incel discourses and narratives observed on (1) the Incel.is forum, (2) the manifestos of Elliot Rodger and Alek Minassian, and (3) previous academic research. This is done to assess the Incel worldview and draw out the narratives and positions around gender that politically motivate Incel violence. Thereafter, the article outlines the emerging political ideologies discernible within Incel spaces and their misogyny-based calls for revolution (Zimmerman 2022). The final section is done in contravention to, or perhaps development upon, the current belief that incels are apolitical (insofar as extreme misogyny can be considered apolitical)—a stance that is used to differentiate the manosphere from the Alt-Right. The most common Incel ideology revolves around a 'Marxist style model of sexual distribution where women are reduced to commodities and distributed equally amongst men' (Zimmerman 2022, 7). Instead of a redistribution of labour forces and wealth, they advocate for a redistribution of power in the sexual marketplace, since, in their worldview, women are analogous to the bourgeoisie hoarding the means of (re)production and exploiting men, the sexual proletariat. This ideology encompasses Incel's misogyny and their dehumanisation of women along with their desire for sex and a sexual revolution (which primarily undoes the sexual revolution of second-wave feminism). The blackpill 'Incel Rebellion' is also undeniably political, since it is a call for political violence. Sentiments such as 'CHAD IS THE ENEMY. FOIDS ARE THE ENEMY. NORMIES ARE THE ENEMY. NON INCELS ARE THE ENEMY' effectively demonstrate the feelings of collective victimhood, feelings of fear and anger towards outgroups, and the belief that political violence is not only acceptable but necessary and legitimate (Zimmerman 2022, 9). Zimmerman proves that incels are 'moving beyond social commentary to become a political movement' (Zimmerman 2022, 10) via critical narrative analysis of Incel discourses available online.

Robert Green, Kurt Fowler, and Allan Palombi have collaborated on multiple articles on various aspects of manosphere discourse, all of which are relevant here. Most recently, the article 'The Black pill pipeline: A process-tracing analysis of the Incel's continuum of violent radicalisation' (Green et al. 2023) tracks the process by which people are indoctrinated into Inceldom, and are subsequently radicalised into increasingly radical 'pills', culminating in the blackpill. Drawing on Doosje et al.'s (2016) tripartite process of radicalisation—*introductory, group membership,* and *action*—Green et al. used content sampling of Incel forums, and then process-tracing, to track the radicalisation process. 'Within Incel culture, "pills" are the metaphorical in vivo terms that appear most often and represent the different stages of their radicalization process' (Green et al. 2023, 5): members will be introduced via the red pill (a term also used by the Alt-Right), before progressing through various pill pathways, such as the racepill, which can culminate in the blackpill. This socialisation process creates a filtering effect, wherein each step concentrates members. Crucially, 'the purpose of the blackpill pipeline is not to simply acknowledge the powerlessness of the individual to enact structural change but to extol that violence is the proper response to this injustice' (Green et al. 2023, 13). While it is true that not every Incel will become blackpilled, and not all blackpillers will enact violence, the expressed approval of these ideas by blackpillers and those progressing through the pipeline make it clear to all Incels that violence is not only acceptable, but appropriate (Green et al. 2023, 15). Green et al. conclude that:

> The blackpill reframes the perceived reality of Incels to include a hopelessness that reframes the struggle of Incels from a problem to be solved (rejection by women), to a social restratification (a return to the perceived strict patriarchy of the midcentury), to a holy war (a recognition that society will not change and violent reprisal is the only acceptable response).
>
> (Green et al. 2023, 17)

This study, utilising Incel's 'pill' discourse, provides a nuanced understanding of the Incel pathway, from indoctrination to inciting violence, from hoping to find love to hoping to 'make it count'.[6]

Fowler, Green, and Palombi have also produced two discursive analyses of Incel's gendered spectrum of political agency (2022; 2023). The first is '*From Chads to Blackpills*, a Discursive Analysis of the Incel's Gendered Spectrum of Political Agency' (2022) and the second is '*From Stacys to Foids*, a Discursive Analysis of the Incel's Gendered Spectrum of Political Agency' (2023). Both articles utilise a methodology of discourse analysis, applied to popular Incel message boards and prominent conversation threads therewithin to shed light on Incel ideologies. *From Chads to Blackpills* focuses on the discourses Incels use to convey the stratification of gender performativity within their subculture, whereas *From Stacys to Foids* focuses on Incel's perceptions of female gender performativity. Both articles find that Incels use sex as a 'central metaphor' to convey sex roles and the gender binary.

This imagistic aspect of Incel thinking is confirmed in Witt's study of the secular canonisation of the Isla Vista killer. It found that Incels have elevated him into the realm of the symbolic and used him as a semiotic object that encompasses their views of the self (a subordinated, suffering self), masculinity, and the world (Witt 2020). Hence, though Incels often position themselves as scientific thinkers, appropriating evolutionary psychology in particular to evince their points (Lucy 2024, 4), their discourse actually tends to be more imagistic, employing metaphors and signifiers to convey meaning. This tendency is also located elsewhere in the manosphere: Dayter and Rüdiger's monograph *The Language of Pick-Up Artists*, similarly found that PUAs use evolutionary biology to explain why men 'need' sex (Dayter and Rüdiger 2022, 122). At the same time, PUA terminology relies on metaphors adapted from military, sports, and business domains, a key example of which being their goal to 'close' the deal with women (Dayter and Rüdiger 2022, 56).

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Thus, linguistic analysis of different communities reveals common ground across the manosphere, in this case their abstracted thinking patterns.

Finally, Lisa Sugiura's monograph *The Incel Rebellion: The Rise of the Manosphere and the Virtual War Against Women* (2021) draws upon research in multiple fields, particularly linguistics and digital studies, to provide a more holistic understanding of the evolution, formation, and spread of Incels. The open-access book provides an informed and cultural understanding into Inceldom and, more broadly, the scope and nature of the manosphere. The book includes within its purview the historical origins of the pre-Internet men's rights movement and its evolution into the online manosphere as well as the role digital technologies play in propagating violence and hatred against women. Regarding digital technologies, there is a particular focus on the ways in which antifeminist rhetoric and ideology on platforms such as YouTube and Reddit deliberately target young boys under the guise of harmless or satirical media (Sugiura 2021a, 2021b, 30). Sugiura's central argument is that although Incels are an 'extreme manifestation of misogyny, their problematic attitudes are not contained to the online spaces they frequent, rather they are symbolic of structural misogyny and patriarchal systems of socialisation', and that Incel ideologies are 'interwoven with the wider socio-political climate' (Sugiura 2021a, 2021b, 31). For Sugiura, misogynistic extremism such as this is not confined to online spaces, but it is exacerbated by digital technologies. The research was undertaken utilising a dual methodology of online ethnography—netnography (Kozinets 2015, 2019 in Sugiura 2021a, 2021b, 44)—and semi-structured interviews with self-identified Incels and ex-Incels. The interviews are peppered throughout the chapters, adding personal insight into the phenomena found and presented via the netnography. *The Incel Rebellion* is divided into chapters that look at the emergence and development of the manosphere; a deep dive into the 'Incel Rebellion'[7]; terrorist and revolutionary facets of the Incel communities; and situating and contextualising Incels within everyday misogyny, the dark web, male supremacism, and political culture wars. Hence, chapters from this book could be included in every section of this literature review, since it looks at Incels within the wider culture of misogyny, the psychology and psychological impact of Inceldom, and the language and discourse used by Incels.

Sugiura concludes that misogynistic ideologies espoused by Incels and the manosphere are linked with the wider sociopolitical climate, and they are amplified by digital technologies (Sugiura 2021a, 2021b, 228). Rather than focussing on the question of whether Incels qualify as terrorists, Sugiura's interest is in the wider harms of the Incel community, which does include incitement of violence and hatred, though it also notably includes, for example, psychological and psychosexual harm to young boys, and the normalisation of Alt-Right ideologies in mainstream society. Sugiura acknowledges that the risk of harm is not just affecting women and wider society, but also 'internally within the incel community, where depression anxiety and suicide ideation are rampant'. However, the vulnerability of many Incel members does not 'counteract or justify the profuse misogyny [of Incels] nor does it warrant sympathy towards those indulging in narcissistic violent fantasies' (Sugiura 2021a, 2021b, 229). Sugiura's holistic approach leads to the conclusion that 'Incel is both a product of digital technologies and the rhetoric of twentieth-century men's movements' (Sugiura 2021a, 2021b, 230). She warns against the oversimplification of Incels as men who hate women because they are denied sex, arguing that the community is comprised of complex issues and individuals navigating masculinity, gender relations, and political polarisation. For Sugiura, while the threat of violent extremism is real and stems from feelings of frustration and entitlement, it is the everyday violence within the incelosphere (misogyny, racism, homophobia, and ableism), along with the ostensible links between the manosphere and the alt-right (Sugiura 2021a, 2021b, 231–2), that need further investigation.

Thus, research into the language and discourses of Incels and other manosphere communities illuminate the ideological underpinnings and inner workings of the manosphere, as well as its position and implications for broader society. However, as shall be covered in more depth in the following conclusion, the linguistic approaches in particular are predominantly focussed on answering the question of 'what?' (What is an Incel? What is the manosphere? What do they believe?) and further studies in this field need to move beyond using linguistic analysis to define the borders of and within the manosphere.

5 | Conclusion

This literature review has located some key findings from the recent research into Incels and the manosphere. These include how the manosphere is born from and shaped by conceptions of masculinity; how to theorise Inceldom in terms of clinical psychology and the potential methods for treating individuals; and the illuminative value of researching the language, culture, and ideologies of the manosphere. However, it has been demonstrated via the multidisciplinary scope that the literature is limited in terms of interdisciplinarity. Most of the literature included within this review failed to look beyond its own discipline in its attempts to theorise and understand the manosphere, leading to significant gaps in knowledge. A notable exception to this is Sugiura's *The Incel Rebellion* (2021), which is a comprehensive analysis of the manosphere. It could equally have been included in the Masculinity Studies and Psychology sections of this review, due to its drawing upon these fields in its theorising of the manosphere. Future research in this field needs to take an interdisciplinary approach. Utilising the interdisciplinarity of a field such as Digital Humanities might provide a useful theoretical framework for researchers aiming for a more overarching method with which to address the manosphere. Moreover, more work needs to follow the example of Kaiser (2022), Zimmerman et al. (2018), and the *Palgrave Handbook of Gendered Violence and Technology* (2021), in their contextualisation of Incels and the manosphere within wider digital and political climates.

The task of synthesising existing research into the manosphere and organising it into disciplines is, in some ways, pre-emptive. Much of the work in this emerging field is exploratory, at the stage of documenting and explaining the phenomenon of the manosphere. Thus, it is difficult to analyse the theoretical

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contributions of each discipline to the wider academic study of the manosphere, given that academics are still in the first, initial stages of studying *what* the manosphere is and establishing *why* it is a necessary field of study. As well as the aforementioned interdisciplinarity, future research in this field should consider their theoretical grounding—and the potential theoretical implications of—their own work. One example of this is an article that argued Connell's model of hegemonic masculinity is misappropriated in Incel studies, as they conflate non-hegemonic dominant or dominating masculine character traits with hegemonic masculinity (Lucy 2024). In this case, we see the value of theoretical contributions for not only understanding the manosphere, but also shaping the field of manosphere studies.

A key field that has been omitted from the scope of this literature review is extra-academic writing on the manosphere. This is to say, texts that have been written for a wider audience. Primary among them is Laura Bates' *Men Who Hate Women* (2020), which is arguably the most comprehensive text on the manosphere to date. Each chapter constitutes a deep dive into one community within the manosphere, starting with Incels, before moving on to Pick-Up Artists, Men Going Their Own Way, Men's Right's Activists, and trolls. She also researches the effect that the manosphere has on female victims of it, male victims who are exploited emotionally and financially by it, male anxiety in a post-#MeToo society, the infiltration of manosphere ideologies in schools, and the male activists who are raising awareness and fighting for change with regard to the manosphere. This comprehensive text is often overlooked in academic research, due to its being a non-fiction publication for general audiences. Nevertheless, it is a key work in the field. Attention may also be paid to Caitlin Moran's *What About Men?* (2023), which is more of a personal reflection on the issues facing men, though it includes within its purview various aspects of the manosphere. Moreover, there is a strong case to be made for the importance of Sugiura's *The Incel Rebellion* (2021) in any research on extra-academic writings on the manosphere; though the author is an academic, the text is deliberately accessible—both in its writing style and its free access on Amazon Books—meaning that it has a wider reach. Ultimately, this literature review demonstrates the value of looking across academic fields, and beyond them, to gain a clearer picture of Incels and the manosphere.

Conflicts of Interest

The author declares no conflicts of interest.

Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available on request from the corresponding author. The data are not publicly available due to privacy or ethical restrictions.

Endnotes

[1] Masculinity Studies employs research methods from across disciplines, blurring the line between this necessarily interdisciplinary field and the others covered in this article. This might be seen to contradict the assertion within this article that there is very little conversation between the fields. While this is arguable, I would alternatively propose that, although they are utilising the research methods, the research included in this section participates in little multidisciplinary conversation.

[2] Gamergate was a harassment campaign in which prominent women in the video games subculture were targeted with misogynistic abuse under the guise of defending ethics in video games journalism (O'Donnell 2022). Gamergate united different online groups and spread 4chan harassment tactics to the political right, gamers, and online anti-feminists, where they continue to be deployed against the 'cultural left' (Nagle 2017, 24).

[3] For a psychological profile of the Alt-right, see (Forscher and Kteily 2020), who analyse the data on the prominence of the Alt-right during the 2016 presidential election; after which, they propose a psychological profile of Alt-right Trump-voters (compared to non-Alt-right Trump-voters and non-Alt-right non-Trump-voters) and ultimately argue for renewed consideration of overt forms of bias in contemporary intergroup research.

[4] Online communication involving hostility, aggression, insults, and offenciveness (Jane 2014, 542).

[5] It is currently Incels.is. Given the hate speech and illegality of the content on Incel forums, they are always at risk of being shut down. Alongside this, Incels' suspicion of out-groups means they sometimes relocate their forums because of a fear of being infiltrated.

[6] The manosphere entreaty to not only commit suicide, but to do so as the culmination of a mass murdering or spree killing.

[7] That is, the processes by which people are indoctrinated into Inceldom, the language and ideology of Incels, Incel spaces and norms, the Blackpill pipeline, and the mental health impact of joining the manosphere.

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